

Wedding Day Portraits: The Couples Posing Guide.

Connection over staging. Real over perfect.

How to be in your portraits, not just stand in them.

- The fundamentals — what makes couple portraits work.
- Standing together — proximity, angle, and connection.
- Walking & movement — how to move naturally together.
- Seated & relaxed poses.
- Hands — how to hold each other without looking staged.
- Expressions & genuine moments — how we create them.
- Your wedding day portraits — what to expect.

NYDAM PHOTOGRAPHY

“Genuine. Intentional. Timeless.”

nydamphoto.com · Austin, Texas · Est. 2008

W E L C O M E

The Best Portraits *Happen Between Poses.*

Not when you're holding something perfectly.
When you forget the camera is there.

*"Every couple says the same thing before portraits: we're not good at this.
By the end, they've stopped thinking about it entirely."*
NYDAM PHOTOGRAPHY

Wedding day portraits are 20–30 minutes of your day. That's not much time — but it's enough to create images you will look at for the rest of your lives, if you know how to use it. This guide exists so you arrive knowing what to expect and what to do with your body, your hands, and each other.

Posing for two is different from posing alone. The connection between you — where you lean, how you hold each other, what you do with the space between you — is what separates portraits that feel alive from portraits that feel performed. We direct all of it. But understanding the principles means you warm up faster.

Read this once together if you can. Practice the chin position and the weight shift. Then on your wedding day, trust the direction and let the rest happen.

W H A T ' S I N S I D E

- 01 The Fundamentals for Couples →
- 02 Standing Together →
- 03 Walking & Movement →
- 04 Seated & Relaxed Poses →
- 05 Hands — How to Hold Each Other →
- 06 Expressions & Genuine Moments →
- 07 Your Wedding Day Portraits →

01

The Fundamentals for Couples.

These principles apply to every pose in this guide. Each one is true for individual portraits and twice as important when there are two of you in the frame.

+ Close the gap.

The space between two people reads as distance on camera. When we say “get closer,” he means it. What feels uncomfortably close to you usually looks exactly right in the frame.

+ Chin forward and down — both of you.

The chin trick applies to everyone. Push the chin slightly forward and down — not up, not back. It defines the jaw, creates a longer neck, and removes the shadows that make people feel self-conscious about photos.

+ Shift your weight. Always.

Equal weight on both feet reads as rigid. Shift 70% of your weight to one leg. Your partner does the same. Suddenly both of you have shape, ease, and visual interest.

+ Turn toward each other first.

Before any pose, the default position is turned slightly toward your partner. Not squared to the camera. Toward each other. The camera captures whatever relationship exists between the two of you. Start with genuine orientation and the pose follows.

+ Relax your shoulders — both of you.

Tension lives in the shoulders first. Before every shot, take a breath and drop them down and back. When both people do this at the same time, the energy of the image changes entirely.

+ Let the moment happen between poses.

The best images almost always come from the transition — when you’re moving from one position to the next, when something is said, when one of you laughs. Don’t reset to neutral between poses. Stay in motion.

+ Look at each other before you look at the camera.

When directed to look at the lens, do it from a position of already being connected to each other. Eyes that come to the camera from real attention read differently from eyes that are just pointed at a lens.

+ Trust the direction completely.

We will tell you exactly what to do with your bodies, your hands, your faces, and where to look. Your only job is to follow the direction and stay present with each other. The portraits take care of themselves.

02

Standing Together.

Standing portraits are where your gown, your suit, and your silhouettes are most visible. The key is proximity, angle, and giving the space between you a reason to exist.

1 Classic Side by Side

Stand shoulder to shoulder, both turned 30–45 degrees from the camera. Partner closest to camera steps slightly in front. Both weight shifts toward each other. Heads tilt slightly together. The foundation pose everything else builds from.

2 The Lean In

One partner leans their forehead or temple against the other's. Eyes can close, look down, or look at each other. Arms around each other's waist or shoulders. Creates intimacy without requiring a kiss.

3 Front and Back

One partner stands behind the other, arms wrapped around from behind. Front partner leans back slightly. Both turn faces toward the camera or toward each other. Shows the gown from the front while creating physical connection.

4 The Forehead Touch

Face each other closely. Touch foreheads. Eyes closed or looking down. Hands on each other's face, chest, or shoulders. One of the most intimate standing poses — works at any point in the session.

5 Against Architecture

One partner leans against a wall, column, or doorframe. The other leans in toward them. Creates a natural, relaxed quality while using the venue. Works especially well in grand hallways, chapels, and archways.

6 The Look Away

Stand together, both looking off in the same direction — not at the camera. One partner's head rests against the other. Creates a contemplative, editorial quality. Best used as a variation after the camera-facing shots are done.

STANDING TIPS

+ Close the gap before every pose.

Couples almost always stand too far apart. Before we shoot, we will close the distance. What feels close is usually exactly right.

+ Height difference: lean into it.

A taller partner should bend toward the shorter one, not stand rigid. The lean creates connection and frames the image naturally.

+ The groom's hand placement.

Small of the back, waist, or shoulder — never hovering. A hand that is placed with intention reads completely differently from one that is just resting nearby.

+ Both weight shifts in the same direction.

When both partners shift weight toward each other simultaneously, the body language reads as mutual draw. Opposite weight shifts pull the image apart visually.

03

Walking & Movement.

Movement is the fastest way to break stiffness in a couple. Walking together, turning together, laughing mid-step — these images are almost always more alive than still poses. Don't perform the movement. Just do it.

MOVEMENT POSES

- + **Walk toward the camera together.**
Start 20 feet back. Walk naturally toward us, side by side or slightly overlapping. Inside hands connected. Eyes can go to the camera, to each other, or ahead. This single prompt produces more usable images than almost anything else.
- + **Walk away and look back.**
Walk away from the camera together. On cue, both look back over the same shoulder. The turn creates a diagonal through the frame and catches you both mid-motion with real expression.
- + **Walk and talk.**
Walk together while actually having a conversation — about anything. Your honeymoon, your morning, something funny. The camera catches the expression of two people genuinely engaged with each other, not performing engagement.
- + **Spin or dip.**
Classic for a reason. One partner leads the other into a spin or a gentle dip. You don't need to be graceful — the camera catches the peak of the motion. Commit fully. Tentative attempts always look tentative.
- + **Run toward each other.**
From 15 feet apart, walk or jog toward each other. The moment of meeting — arms out, closing the gap — is one of the most joyful frames from any portrait session.

IN-BETWEEN MOMENTS

- + **The adjustment.**
One partner straightens the other's tie, brushes something from their shoulder, fixes a strand of hair. These small acts of care photograph as completely real because they are.
- + **The whisper.**
One partner leans to whisper something in the other's ear. Doesn't matter what — what matters is the reaction. This is one of our most-used prompts because the response is almost always genuine.
- + **The reaction.**
we say something. You react. The best portraits from most sessions come from exactly this: not a directed expression, but a real response to something unexpected.
- + **Between poses — still shooting.**
When you're shaking out your hands, resetting, laughing about something — the camera is still running. Some of the most used images come from these unguarded seconds.
- + **The look.**
Turn and look at your partner the way you actually look at them when they're not watching. we will position to catch it. It requires nothing from you except stopping to actually see each other.

04

Seated & Relaxed Poses.

Seated and ground-level poses produce some of the most natural images of any portrait session. Lower energy, easier to relax into, and the physical closeness they require creates genuine connection.

Steps or a ledge.

Sitting on steps, a low wall, or a venue ledge. One partner one step higher than the other — creates height variety and brings faces closer together. Works in almost every venue with any architecture.

Lap sit.

One partner sits across the other's lap or knees. Arms around each other. Faces close. One of the most intimate and playful seated poses. Commit to it fully — tentative attempts always look tentative.

Ground sit — side by side.

Both seated on the ground, legs extended or bent to one side. One partner leaning on the other. Gown spread intentionally around both of you. Creates beautiful frame-filling images.

Ground sit — facing each other.

Cross-legged or knees bent, facing each other closely. Hands holding. Foreheads touching or faces close. The physical frame of the image becomes the two of you in your own world.

One standing, one seated.

One partner sits or perches on a surface. The other stands behind or beside, leaning in. Creates height variety without anyone towering over the other. Works beautifully against architectural backdrops.

Reclining in the grass.

Both lying in the grass, side by side or one propped on an elbow. Low angle from us creates an intimate, story-driven image. Best in the golden hour when grass is warm and light is directional.

The bench.

Side by side on a bench, turned toward each other. One arm around the other's shoulder. Lean in. The bench provides structure; your closeness provides the story.

Lean forward together.

Both seated, both leaning forward with elbows on knees. Faces close, looking at each other or both at camera. Creates engaged, intentional energy — never slouched.

Use the venue floor.

Ballroom floors, hardwood, stone — seated images on beautiful venue surfaces create context that outdoor shots can't replicate. The floor is part of the image.

THE ONE RULE

Seated poses work when you lean toward each other, not away. Always close the gap.

05

Hands — How to Hold Each Other.

How two people hold each other communicates everything about their relationship. Hands that hang, hover, or grip too tight all read on camera. Here is what works — and why.

HOW TO HOLD

+ Interlaced fingers — the natural hold.

Fingers fully interlaced, hands held at hip height or at the side. Not gripped tightly — relaxed, the way you hold hands walking. This is the most natural and photographically clean hand connection.

+ One hand, loose hold.

One partner holds the other's hand with a loose, natural grip. The held hand relaxes completely. Often more elegant than both hands fully interlaced.

+ Hands on waist or small of the back.

One or both hands placed flat on the partner's waist or lower back. With intention — not hovering an inch away. A placed hand communicates confidence and connection. A hovering hand communicates uncertainty.

+ Both hands on chest or lapels.

Both hands flat on the partner's chest, or lightly holding their lapels. Works beautifully in formal portraits and forehead-touch poses. Creates visual balance and physical closeness simultaneously.

+ Cupped face.

One or both hands gently cupping the partner's face. Used before a kiss, in the forehead touch, or in an emotional moment. One of the most intimate hand positions in portrait photography.

+ Arms around each other.

Full arms-around-waist or arms-around-shoulder hold. Both partners' hands should be doing something specific: flat on the other's back, fingers on the arm, or visible and intentional. Hands that dangle off someone's shoulder read as accidental.

+ Bouquet as anchor.

The bride's bouquet gives one hand a clear purpose. Hold it at hip height — never at chest. The free hand is available for the partner connection. When the bouquet is at hip height, the gown and the neckline stay visible.

+ Soft, curved fingers always.

Whether hands are at the side, at the waist, or resting anywhere — keep fingers slightly curved, not stiff and straight. Rigid fingers read as tense. A natural loose curl is almost invisible on camera.

THE ONE RULE

Place your hands with intention. Hovering reads as uncertainty. Placed reads as confidence.

06

Expressions & Genuine Moments.

The expression on your face when you look at your partner is the most irreplaceable element in any portrait. It cannot be directed into existence — only created. Here is how we create it.

EXPRESSION TYPES

+ The real laugh.

we will earn this. He will say something, prompt something, or create a situation that produces genuine laughter. Your only job: don't suppress it when it comes. Real laughter in a couple portrait is the image that gets framed.

+ The serious look — both at the camera.

No smiles. Both looking directly into the lens. Confident, present, together. This is the editorial portrait that appears in every luxury wedding feature. It requires nothing from you except stillness and presence.

+ The soft smile — at each other.

Looking at your partner with a slight smile — not a full grin, not forced. The expression that happens when you're happy and the person you love is right in front of you. We create the conditions for it. It arrives on its own.

+ Eyes closed.

Both eyes closed, faces close or foreheads touching. Removes self-consciousness entirely. Creates an intimate, still quality that works beautifully in both black and white and color.

+ Our prompts — how they work.

During the portrait session, we give prompts designed to produce genuine reactions rather than performed expressions. Some will seem odd. Follow them anyway. The results are almost always the images you end up loving most.

+ The whisper prompt.

One partner whispers something in the other's ear. What is said doesn't matter — what matters is the response. A surprised laugh, a smile that breaks through, a moment of warmth. we position to catch it before it disappears.

+ The forehead touch with eyes closed.

Both eyes closed, foreheads together. Then on cue, both slowly open eyes and look at each other. The moment of that mutual gaze — after eyes open — is consistently one of the most emotional frames of the session.

+ The look when they don't know you're watching.

we will position one partner and then give the other a moment to simply look at them — without being told how to look. The unguarded expression that follows is the one that belongs above the fireplace.

07

Your Wedding Day Portraits.

This is how the portrait session fits into your wedding day — what to expect, how to make the most of the time, and what you never need to manage.

HOW LONG YOU ACTUALLY HAVE

Most couples have 20–30 minutes for portraits. That is enough — if the time is protected. we work efficiently within whatever window your timeline allows. If you can protect 45 minutes, the variety increases significantly. Talk to your coordinator about building in a real portrait window, not just the time left over after everything else.

THE FIRST LOOK OPTION

A first look — seeing each other privately before the ceremony — is the single most effective way to improve wedding day portraits. It gives you 20 minutes of portrait time before the ceremony, when you're fresh, unhurried, and fully present with each other. After the ceremony, portraits compete with guests, family formals, and the timeline. Before the ceremony, it's just the two of you.

THE PORTRAIT WINDOW AFTER CEREMONY

If you're not doing a first look, portraits happen after the ceremony, before cocktail hour ends. The couple is introduced, briefly excused, and portraits are made. we move fast. You stay present. Having this guide in advance means the direction lands immediately instead of requiring explanation while the clock is running.

WHAT ARLEN HANDLES

Location scouting, light reading, posing direction, expression prompts, timing, and every technical decision. Your job is to follow direction and stay in contact with each other. You don't need to remember poses, worry about angles, or think about anything except being present.

THE GOLDEN HOUR

If your timeline allows for outdoor portraits in the 30–60 minutes before sunset, this is when the most cinematic and editorial images happen. Warm, directional light that photographs beautifully on white fabric and skin. Build this window into your timeline if you can. Tell your coordinator it matters.

AFTER THE SESSION

Sneak peek within 48 hours. Full edited gallery within 4–6 weeks. From your gallery you can download, print, and share directly. Your album selections are made from your gallery once you've had time to look.

*“We come prepared. Every session planned with intention.
And then we create something real.”*

08

What to Expect — & Our Collections.

Every wedding we photograph is different. What portrait time looks like on your day depends on your venue, your ceremony format, and which collection you choose. Here is what stays consistent — and what changes.

TWO PHOTOGRAPHERS — ALWAYS

Every Nydam Photography wedding is covered by two photographers working simultaneously. One with you, one with your partner — getting ready, ceremony, and throughout the day. Nothing is missed because no single photographer can be in two places at once. Both photographers maintain the same editorial, cinematic standard across every image delivered.

OUR COLLECTIONS

Essential Collection

\$2,500 + tax

Ceremony coverage and couple & close family portraits. Designed for intimate ceremonies, elopements, and courthouse weddings. Both photographers present. Full private online gallery with print ordering.

MOST POPULAR

Signature Collection — Most Popular

\$4,500 + tax

Full wedding day coverage from getting ready through reception, with both photographers working your entire day. Includes a complimentary engagement session before the wedding and a professionally designed lay-flat heirloom album. This is the collection most couples choose.

Wedding Story Collection

\$6,500 + tax

Full weekend coverage: rehearsal dinner, complete wedding day, and a day-after portrait session. Also includes a complimentary bridal portrait session and engagement session. Both photographers throughout. Professionally designed heirloom album. For couples who believe no moment of the weekend is too small to remember.

[VIEW FULL DETAILS & RESERVE YOUR DATE](#)nydamphoto.com/wedding-packages

Questions? Reach us at arlen.nydham@gmail.com or 512-955-4520

About Nydam Photography.

We have been photographing Austin families, seniors, couples, and milestones since 2008. Every session we do is personal. We arrive prepared — every session planned with intention — and we create something real.

We photograph with natural light and flash — almost always, even outdoors — because the quality of the image matters more than the convenience of the approach. Every image is considered. Every detail is intentional.

GENUINE

Every portrait should feel like you — not a polished version of someone else. We create the conditions for real moments, then capture them.

INTENTIONAL

Light, posing, expression, timing — every element of a great portrait is considered in advance and guided with care throughout.

TIMELESS

We edit for longevity, not for trends. The images we create together are meant to stop you in your tracks ten years from now.

Weddings · Families & Portraits · Seniors · Sacraments · Quinceañeras · Events · Sports · Corporate Headshots & Branding

Every specialty. One standard of care.

KNOW SOMEONE WHO DESERVES THIS?

Pass this guide along — or send them directly to us. The right photographer changes everything. If you found yours — share that gift. A referral from a client is the highest compliment we receive.

With warmth,

Arlen and Tanya Nydam, Nydam Photography

nydamphoto.com · arlen.nydam@gmail.com